

June 14, 2026

INFORMS Prize Committee for the Teaching of OR/MS Practice
c/o Institute for Operations Research and the Management Sciences

Re: Letter of Support, Nomination of Prof. Mohammad Dehghani for the INFORMS Prize for the Teaching of OR/MS Practice (2026)

Dear Committee Members,

I am writing to support the nomination of Professor Mohammad Dehghani for the INFORMS Prize for the Teaching of OR/MS Practice. I took IE 5374: Applied Generative AI at Northeastern University's MIE department, and I can say without qualification that it was the most practically formative course of my graduate program, and one of the more useful things I have done for my career, full stop.

I currently work as an AI Solutions Engineer at Microsoft on the Dynamics 365 AI team, focused on agentic systems and enterprise deployment. My day-to-day involves exactly the kind of reasoning this course taught: how do you build AI that actually works in production, not just in a notebook? That framing, from concept to deployed system, was baked into everything we did.

Two things from the course stand out as particularly high leverage. The first is the depth on RAG pipelines and agent frameworks. We did not just learn what retrieval-augmented generation is, we built it, broke it, and debugged why chunking strategy or embedding choice degraded retrieval quality. That hands-on exposure to LangChain, LangGraph, and multi-agent orchestration gave me a working mental model that I now use when scoping implementation projects for enterprise clients. When I encounter a new Dynamics 365 deployment scenario, I know how to think about it because I have already built a version of it.

The second is the live demo culture. Every project was presented as a working prototype, not a slide deck summarizing what you intended to build. That distinction matters enormously. It forces rigor, you cannot hide behind a roadmap when your agent is running live in front of the room, and it builds the kind of communication skill that shows up in technical interviews and client conversations. I walked into interviews with demonstrable projects, not descriptions of coursework. I believe that difference contributed directly to landing my role at Microsoft.

Professor Dehghani ran the course with consistent intellectual seriousness. The weekly GenAI news rounds kept us current with a field that moves fast enough to make yesterday's curriculum feel dated. He pushed us to understand the fundamentals, temperature, tokens, embeddings, context windows, not as trivia but as variables you tune when something is not working. That grounding made everything else more durable.

IE 5374 is the kind of course that warrants recognition precisely because it resists the easier path of teaching GenAI as a tool to use and instead treats it as a domain to understand and build in. I am glad to recommend Professor Dehghani for this award.

Sincerely,

Sheetal Naik

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